

Will The E-book Take Over?

HERE'S A QUESTION that's been playing in my head a couple of weeks now: is it at all possible that what Apple's iPod did to the Discman and CD players, electronic books might do to books?

With digitisation of books in progress at many large libraries, with search engines, too, getting into it and publishers even geared up to launch future titles in both printed and digital versions, one is apt to wonder about the future of the printed word, especially books. Concerns have been expressed about the possible switch in our reading habits as well as its commercial impact: will digital technology spell doom for print? And is that a good thing?

A rough estimate states that Google is digitising around 10 million books a year, while the overall number of titles that exist today is about 65 million.

Well, people do want to read excerpts online and base book purchase decisions on their online reading experience, but can you imagine reading a gripping Alvin Toffler or Robert Ludlum on screen, having to adjust your posture, brightness and viewing angle every five minutes?

The latest e-book tool launched by Sony is called the Reader, a book-sized gadget that reads PDFs and JPEGs as well as MP3 and AAC e-books. Its batteries let you read up to 7,500 pages, and it stores up to 80 books. Sony currently makes 12,000 books available online for download.

It seems to me that the most affected by the digital changeover will be sales of reference books and encyclopaedias. Wikipedia, the free and collaborative online resource, for instance, has already caused a dip in the sales of the print version of the Encyclopaedia Britannica and various reference journals. Printed dictionaries, too, have taken a hit from their online counterparts. Books that one would not necessarily read from cover to cover might cease to exist in the printed form, because searching a well-indexed book online is quicker and much more convenient. Additionally, what might likely migrate online are telephone directories, cookbooks, and perhaps textbooks.



Deepak Ajwani Executive Editor

“The most affected by the digital changeover will be reference works”

Most authors and their creations, however, will never find a better medium than the paper-bound book. Readers engrossed in a novel, for instance, would certainly not want to be encumbered by connectivity concerns, back-up power, or any other distractions—such as multiple links on a page.

People want a media suitable for unhurried reading in bed, in the loo, on the beach. Printed books are not just a source of information, as we all know: they also look and feel good. They even smell good. They find a place in a well-designed, proudly-owned bookshelf. I think it'll be a while before we change our idea about what “reading a book” means.

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'D. Ajwani'.

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